WHY WE ARE A TWO-WHEELER NATION

Because they offer freedom and flexibility. But the overwhelming reliance on two-wheelers for daily commutes is a reflection of the gaps in our public transport and poor urban planning

By AVISHEK G. DASTIDAR

For five years, Mohit Kashyap, now 30, would cycle seven kilometres from his home in Chirag Dilli to Sundar Nagar, where he worked as a gardener. The journey would take him 45 minutes. Then came marriage and a Honda Activa scooter as a wedding gift, which reduced his commute by 25 minutes. Of course, he could also take Bus No. 419, which would get him close to his place of work in 15 minutes. Yet he rarely takes it. "*Seat nahin milti. Kabhi late bhi ho jaata hai* (I can't find a seat. Sometimes, it's late too)," he says.

Kashyap's choice reflects a larger trend in how India travels. According to the country's first National Household Travel Survey (NHTS), among Indians travelling at least one kilometre to work, 42.6 per cent primarily use two-wheelers. In cities, the share rises to 52.3 per cent. Urban buses carry just 9.2 per cent of commuters, while metros, suburban trains, monorails and trams together account for another 5 per cent. Cars, in comparison, account for a mere 5.7 per cent.

"We were taken aback by the large share of two-wheelers," says R. Gopalakrishnan, an Indian Railway Traffic Service officer and divisional railway manager, Secunderabad, who was part of the expert group that designed the survey. "We were perhaps not ready for the fact that public transport penetration is so very low."

The ministry of railways had sought such a survey for six years to guide investment and service planning. Conventional transport statistics offered an incomplete picture, says Saurabh Garg, secretary, ministry of statistics and programme implementation (MoSPI), which conducted the exercise. "For the first time, the survey puts people's actual needs at the centre of that data," adds Gopalakrishnan.

The findings help explain the enduring appeal of two-wheelers. According to the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM), Indians bought 21.7 million motorcycles and scooters in FY26, up 10.7 per cent from 19.6 million the previous year and 44 per cent from 15.1 million five years ago. Two-wheelers account for more than 77 per cent of new vehicle sales.

"A good public transport system will not be at the cost of two-wheeler demand and sales," says P.K. Banerjee, former executive director of SIAM. "Rural India moves on two-wheelers. Cities need two-wheelers because buses can't go to doorsteps. Otherwise, who is interested in investing and keeping an asset that is underutilised? People want that freedom."

A RIDE OF THEIR OWN

Two-wheelers are the preferred choice for work commutes, but how Indians get around varies by location, purpose and gender

52.3
PER CENT
of urban workers in India who travel at least 1 km to work primarily use two-wheelers

25
MINUTES
Average one-way commute to a fixed workplace; in urban India, it goes up to 27 minutes

25.8
PER CENT
of urban women workers use two-wheelers as their primary mode of commute, compared with 57% of men

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